AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

Build and Activate the Checkpoint Map

How do I build and activate checkpoints that protect the work?

MODULE 4 · LESSON 3 | CONTROL: CONFIDENCE | Action lesson · 10–12 min

THE CORE IDEA

Control works best when embedded into normal work — not added afterward.

A rule the team knows is not a control. A specific moment where the right question gets asked — consistently — is.

1 Two shortcuts that don't work

Two shortcuts tempt most managers: telling the team about the risks and trusting awareness to change behavior (mid-workday, it won't — not reliably), or writing the checks into a shared document and calling it done (under pressure, nobody remembers to consult it). The Checkpoint Map is different: the map is only the record — the control is each question **anchored to its moment in the work**, asked without anyone having to remember. The plan: build, activate, check it's working, keep it current.

2 What the Checkpoint Map is

TERM — CHECKPOINT MAP

The output of Control: named verification moments embedded in team workflows, each written as **When → What → Who** — the moment a risk is likely to appear, the check that catches it, and the person responsible for asking.

A complete map for one area of work — a client briefing:

Confirm no client data will be used in AI prompts
When: before drafting begins · **Who:** the team member

Verify figures and benchmarks against confirmed sources
When: before the outline is finalized · **Who:** the team member

Second-person read-through: tone, accuracy, appropriateness
When: before the draft goes to the client · **Who:** a colleague

3 Two entry points

If the team's workflows aren't written down, **start from where you see risk** — the moments this module's scans already surfaced — and write a checkpoint for each; three or four standalone lines is enough. If key workflows or SOPs are documented, **start from those**: walk each one, ask where risk enters — data going in, output feeding a decision, work going external — and hang a checkpoint on every yes. Both work; the second scales best for shared recurring processes.

4 The build: three questions per area of work

Either way, the build is the same — done with the people who do the work; the moments belong to them.

THREE BUILD QUESTIONS

1. **Where could AI-related risk enter – and reach a consequence?** Not where AI is used generally; where something going wrong would matter.
2. **At that moment, what is the simplest check?** One question, under two minutes – your data and review agreements usually already say what must be true. Too complex to be done isn't a control.
3. **Who applies it?** Name the person. Named accountability makes the check happen; assumed accountability means it probably won't.

Agentic AI: an agent takes a sequence of actions, not just an output, so risk can appear *during* the process. Two boundary checks – before it starts: what is it allowed to do, and not? After it finishes: can we see what it did? If actions are hard to undo, the before-check is critical.

Write each answer as one line – **When** → **What** → **Who**. That is the Checkpoint Map.

5 Activation: four things

Where it lives
In the flow of work – the same shared space as the Team Working Standard. Not in a folder.

How it's introduced
A document the team **confirms**, not a policy they receive; the manager holds the line when a check gets skipped.

The first time it's used
It becomes real the first time a checkpoint is asked in real work: *"Before this goes out – have we run the source check?"*

Consistency and accountability
Same checks, same moments, every time – and everyone knows which check is theirs.

6 Check it's working – and keep it current

Your part is not running the checks – it is **checking that they run**: *"Before this went out – did we run the source check?"* When the answer is no, ask what happened – unclear checkpoint, skipped under pressure, or wrong place? – to learn, not to blame. Then one quarterly question, alongside the standard's check-in: *"Are these checkpoints still working – and still in the right places?"* Revisit sooner when an error gets through, a new tool arrives, or an agent enters the work – and when something goes wrong, ask not "why did this happen?" but **"at which moment was the checkpoint missing?"**

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Build the map with your team – one recurring AI-involved task first.
- Write every checkpoint as one line – **When** → **What** → **Who** – and keep each check under two minutes.
- Put the map where the team works, share it as a draft to confirm – then activate it out loud with the first real checkpoint question.
- Check that checks run, and use the quarterly question to keep the map in the right places.

Module 4 · Control: Confidence – the moments, the checks, and the owners that protect decisions, data, and outside trust.
Next: Module 5 · Lesson 5.1 – Why People Resist AI – and Why Forcing It Doesn't Work – the Lead move begins.